

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 790

By Atchley

A RESOLUTION to recognize fire protection services as an essential service.

WHEREAS, the safety, health, and welfare of the citizens of Tennessee are the primary responsibility of the State and local governments; and

WHEREAS, fire protection services constitute the first line of defense for Tennessee communities, not only against the ravages of fire but also as primary responders to medical emergencies, hazardous materials incidents, natural disasters, and technical rescues; and

WHEREAS, the dedicated men and women of Tennessee's fire services, encompassing career, part-time, and volunteer professionals across the Volunteer State, place their lives in jeopardy daily to protect the lives and property of their neighbors; and

WHEREAS, the availability of robust fire protection services is directly linked to the economic vitality of the State, influencing homeowner and business insurance rates through ISO ratings and ensuring the continuity of business operations; and

WHEREAS, historically, while law enforcement and emergency medical services are frequently codified as essential services, fire protection has often been viewed as a discretionary service in certain jurisdictions, leading to disparities in funding, resources, and staffing stability; and

WHEREAS, the recent increase in call volumes, the complexity of modern emergency response, and the challenges regarding recruitment and retention of qualified personnel require that fire protection be elevated to a status that reflects its critical nature; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that the State of Tennessee recognizes fire protection services as an essential

service and encourages all local governments in this State to ensure that fire protection services are available to all residents of this State.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.